

# Alberuni's India

## (1017–30 CE)

On the new moon day in the month of Kartika, the Hindus celebrate a festival called Dibali, wrote the Persian traveller Alberuni in 1030 CE. People 'bathe, dress festively, make presents to each other of betel-leaves and areca-nuts; they ride to the temples to give alms and play merrily with each other till noon. In the night they light a great number of lamps in every place'.[1]

'The cause of this festival,' writes Alberuni, 'is that Lakshmi, the wife of Vasudeva, once a year on this day liberates Bali, the son of Virocana, who is a prisoner in the seventh earth.' Bali comes out into the world. 'The Hindus maintain that this time was a time of luck in the Kritayuga [Satyuga], and they are happy' that this feast-day resembles that time. In Alberuni's day, the festival of lights seems not to have been associated with a man liberating his imprisoned wife but with a woman liberating an imprisoned man—a story that appears in the Chandogya Upanishad.

Alberuni also writes about a festival called Shivratri, when 'they worship Mahadeva during the whole night; they remain awake, and do not lie down to sleep, and offer to him perfumes and flowers'. At pilgrimage sites, Alberuni is impressed by the tanks and step wells that the Hindus construct for their ablutions. 'In this they have attained to a very high degree of art, so that our people (the Muslims), when they see them, wonder at them, and are